

Analysis of Contemporary Economic Issues

Guidance 1: Practical Sessions & Presentation Skills

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2026



**SOLVAY BRUSSELS SCHOOL
ECONOMICS & MANAGEMENT**

Outline

- 1 Course Logistics & Introduction
- 2 PowerPoint Tips & Tricks
- 3 Body Language & Soft Skills

Schedule and Objectives

Guidance Schedule

Mondays, 14h – 16h, S.UA6.106/110 (Starting February 23rd)

Two Main Objectives:

- ① **Soft Skills:** Help you acquire the necessary skills to make a great presentation.
- ② **Hard Skills:** Help you understand technical concepts, graphs, and vocabulary of the course.

Who are we?

Eliott SEMPLICINO

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- BA3 in Economics.
- 1st year as guidance assistant.

Killian Cuvelier

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- BA3 in Economics.
- 1st year as guidance assistant.
- Future : Master of Research in Economics at ECARES ULB

Do not hesitate to contact us if you have any question about the course !

TP Groups Organization

Assignment Rules

- **10 TP Groups** in total.
- Each student is assigned to **ONE** presentation group and **ONE** TP group.
- Each group has **TWO** sessions in total.
- You cannot request a specific group.

Each student:

- Prepare one presentation with its presentation group.
- Attend two TP sessions.
- Present once (during one of the two TP sessions, see schedule)
- **You are already assigned to a group, check UV!**

Structure of TP Sessions

Duration: 2 Hours per session (3 Presentations per session).

For Presenters

- Topics sent 3 weeks in advance.
- **Q&A:** One oral question from assistants/students after presentation.
- The answer counts towards the grade.

For the Audience

- **Task:** Answer ONE written question at the end of the session.
- **Bonus:** You can avoid the written question by asking a **good-quality oral question** to presenters.

Grading Scheme

Requirement: Do ONE group presentation + Attend ONE additional session during which you will watch other student present.

Total Grade: /8

- **3 points:** Group Grade. Cohesion, organization, policy solutions.
- **3 points:** Personal Grade. Content, presentation skills, clarity.
- **1 point:** Question for presenters (Asked by the assistant or by students).
- **1 point:** Question for non-presenters (Written question OR Oral question asked during the other session).
- TP grade is **40% of the final grade**, written exam in June is 60%.
- **Second session** : Oral or written exam, based on course content (100%).

How to prepare your presentation

- 1 **Contact:** Get in touch with group members immediately.
- 2 **Structure:** Discuss content and structure together.
- 3 **Research:** Read provided materials + search for new ones.
- 4 **Cohesion:** Prepare together. Ensure everyone understands ALL parts.
- 5 **Practice:** Repeat together for clarity.
- 6 **Grading:** There is a **GROUP GRADE**. Ensure your teammates are as ready as you are.

Presentation Requirements

Strict Rules

- **Equal Time:** All members must present an equal amount of time.
- **No Notes:** Visual support must be SLIDES ONLY. Reading notes loses the audience.
- **Timing:** Respect the given time limit of 30mins (T-A will stop you).

Mandatory Content Structure:

- Background information.
- Problem definition.
- **Link to theory** seen in lectures.
- Policy options.
- Group opinion.

Background and Visuals

- **Contrast:** Text must contrast with the background.
- **Colors:** Avoid flashy colors.
- **Patterns:** Be careful with shapes/patterns (use them only for originality).
- **Typography:**
 - Avoid ALL-CAPS. **Prefer bold.**
 - Avoid Serif fonts (difficult to read on screen). Use **Sans Serif** (Arial, Helvetica...).
- **Hierarchy:** The first thing you see must be the main content.

Make it Big: Font Sizes

- This is Arial 14 (Too small)
- This is Arial 20 (Still small)
- This is Arial 24 (Minimum size)
- This is Arial 28 (Better)
- **This is Arial 36 (Good for Titles)**

Rule of thumb: Size should be at least 24.

Keep it Simple

Avoid:

- Too many colors.
- Too many fonts and styles.
- Distracting transitions/sound effects.
- *Italics* (hard to read).
- Underlines (confused with hyperlinks).

Prefer:

- Normal or **Bold** fonts.
- "Quotes" instead of italics.
- Consistent styling.

Standard Presentation Structure

- ➊ **Title Slide:** Title, People, Date, University/Logo.
- ➋ **Table of Contents:** Essential to check logical flow.
- ➌ **Introduction:**
 - Brief context/background.
 - Concise explanation of the issue/problem.
- ➍ **Body:**
 - Discuss points in logical order.
 - **Link ideas to class theory.**
- ➎ **Conclusion:**
 - Summarize key points.
 - Remind significance/aims.
 - Group opinion.

Example: Making it Clear

Avoid walls of text.

Better approach (Bullet points):

- Microsoft PowerPoint is a presentation program.
- Created by Robert Gaskins and Dennis Austin (Forethought).
- Released: April 20, 1987 (Macintosh only).
- Acquired by Microsoft for \$14 million (3 months later).
- Integrated into Office suite in 1989/1990.
- Market share: Estimated at 95%.

Content Rules (Text)

80% Rule

80% of content should be in bullet points.

- **Quantity:** 5 or 6 bullet points max per slide.
- **Timing:** Aim for 1 minute of speech per slide.
- **Phrasing:** No complete sentences. Use **Key Words**.
- **No details:** Do not go beyond what is on the slide visually, but explain orally.
- **Tip:** Prepare slides *at the same time* as the presentation. Don't write a text script.

Using Pictures and Data

Pictures:

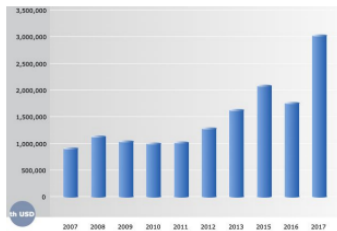
- Great to visualize concepts.
- One important picture per slide.
- Don't write text *on* the picture.
- **Always cite sources!**

Numbers & Tables:

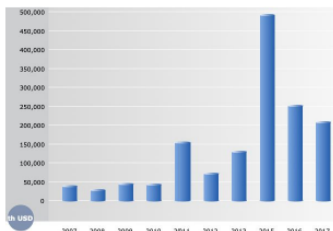
- Avoid massive tables.
- Too much data kills the message.

Visualizing Data: Graphs

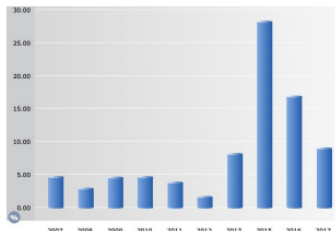
Turnover



Net income



Profit Margin



- **Highlight key trends:** Don't just show the graph.
- Use circles or arrows to focus attention (e.g., "Sharp increase in 2017").
- Comment on the slopes: "Gradually increases", "Slight decrease".

Hyperlinks & Sources

Hyperlinks: Use them for web pages, files, slides, or emails.

(Insert > Link > Web Page or File)

Reliable Sources

- **Cible+ / ULB Library:** Articles, books, thesis.
- **Google Scholar:** Academic articles/journals.
- **Official Sources:** (.org, institutions).
- **News Sources:** Reputable media.
- **Wikipedia:** Good for starting, but **don't quote directly**.
- **AI:** Not a source, but a tool to find sources.

You want to tell something to your audience.

Keep that in mind.

Lower Body: Occupy the Space



- **Static:** Space your feet (don't stand like a soldier).
- **Dynamic:** Move slowly. Moving is a tool.
- **Avoid OCDs:** Repetitive nervous movements.
- **Occupy your space.**

Upper Body: Posture & Voice

- **Be Proud:** Chin up, chest out.
- **Orientation:** Face your audience.
- **Obstacles:** Be careful with chairs, tables, desks (don't hide behind them).
- **Voice:** Speak loudly, project from your chest.



Arms, Gestures & Eyes



Arms:

- "Open" position.
- Gestures can support your speech.
- Warning: Excessive gestures can be distracting.

The Look:

- Look at your audience.
- Look at **everyone** (scan the room).

Everyone has been there. People are here to listen to you.

Last Tips

- More prepared = Less stressed.
- Use **silences** effectively.
- Plan smooth transitions.
- **REPETITION** is key.

Any Questions?